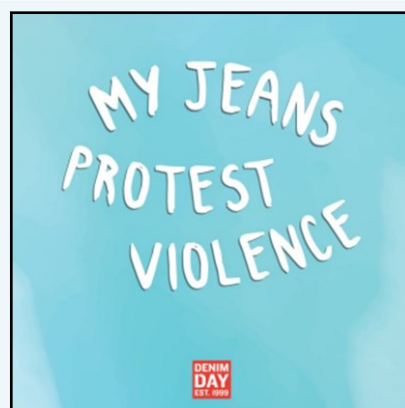


April is Child Abuse Awareness Month

Raise Awareness for Child Abuse Prevention

Wear blue or denim on April 30, 2025, to raise awareness for child abuse prevention and to support survivors of domestic violence.

Note. From *Jeans Protest* [Infographic], by Caltech, n.d., Caltech (<https://equity.caltech.edu/campus-advocate/peace-over-violence-resources>).



Sentinel Injuries

A sentinel injury is a relatively minor injury in a pre-cruising infant that is poorly explained and, therefore, is a concerning sign of potential child physical abuse.

How do they present?

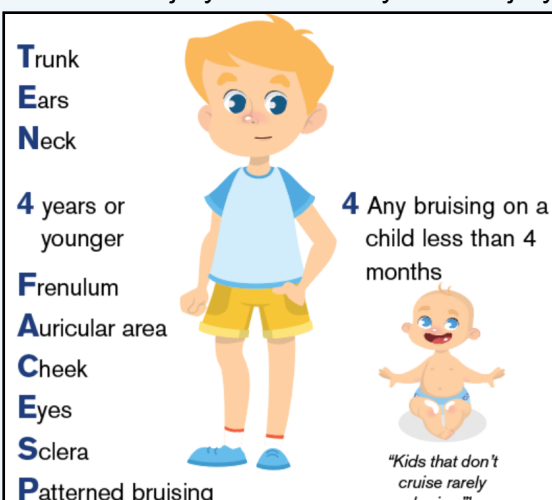
- 80% Bruising
- 11% intraoral injury/bleeding
- 7% other

When do they occur?

- 66% in patients < 3 months
- 95% occur in patients ≤ 7 months

Does a sentinel injury correlate with abuse?

- 27.5% of abused infants had a prior sentinel injury



Note. From *Sentinel Injuries* [Infographic], by ACEP Now, n.d., ACEP Now (<https://www.acepnow.com/article/ten-4-faces-p-a-mnemonic-to-help-you-spot-signs-of-child-abuse/>).

Clinical Case Quiz

A 7-week-old female was fussy during a car ride. Her mother pulled over and noted some blood in the mouth. The mother cleaned the wound and gave milk to wash out the blood.

That night, the infant continued to have pain and difficulty feeding. The mother walked into the room to feed and found the infant sleeping on the belly with blood on the sheets. The mother saw a scratch on the upper part of the gum that attaches to the lip. The infant developed a low-grade fever that resolved.

The mother called GCN due to trouble feeding, possible fever, and because the infant was spitting up brown fluid that the mother thought was old blood. She thought the blood was from the infant falling asleep with the pacifier in her mouth.

What would you do?

- Refer to ED
- Continue regular feeding and monitor for worsening
- Call CPS
- Follow up with PCP
- More than 1 answer is correct



An upper frenulum tear in an infant.

Note. From *Upper Frenulum Tear* [Photograph], by Julia Magana and Mary Ryan, 2020, *Prepare for the Pediatric Emergency Medicine Board* (https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-3-030-28372-8_17).

What's the Best First Step?

Get this child evaluated immediately.

The Role of the Mandated Reporter

What should a mandated reporter do before reporting any allegations of abuse/neglect?

- Have clear and sufficient evidence of abuse or neglect.
- Discuss the concerns with the parent or guardian of the child.
- Talk to the child about what to say to the Child Protective Services worker.
- Have reasonable cause to suspect the child has been abused or neglected.

Where Can I Find Reporting Information?

[Report Abuse Now.](#)

The answer is e. Consider a, c, and d.

The answer is d.

Discussion

Hesitancy to report suspected child abuse can stem from fear of repercussions, lack of knowledge, or cultural norms, but it's crucial to report any suspicion to protect children. Mandated reporters are legally required to report suspected child abuse or neglect if they have a reasonable suspicion based on their professional training and experience. In many states, failure to report by mandated reporters is a crime.

What Constitutes Reasonable Suspicion?

A reasonable suspicion means that, based on facts and your professional training and experience, it is objectively reasonable to suspect that a child is being abused or neglected.

Back to Our Case

We are in a unique position to encourage parents to follow up with a team that can also help to schedule follow-ups. This parent reached out, and we should engage the parent's trust and encourage the parent to have this child evaluated immediately.



Bruises at different stages of healing; the linear shape is highly suggestive of physical abuse.

Note. From *Skin Signs of Child Abuse* [Photograph], by Jordi Pou, 2012, *ACTAS Dermo-Sifiliograficas* (<https://actasdermo.org/en-skin-signs-in-child-abuse-articulo-S1578219012000650>).

Six weeks later, the infant, who was not yet rolling, presented for an outpatient visit with leg swelling. She had bruises on her trunk and face.

A skeletal survey revealed a tibia fracture, multiple rib fractures, and distal radius fracture. A CT showed multiple old subdural bleeds.

Have a low threshold to report or have patient evaluated. It is better to report and be wrong than not report. The onus is not on us to have all the evidence. It is our duty to report if there is simply suspicion.

Those who don't cruise, rarely bruise!

References

ACEP Now. (n.d.). *Sentinel Injuries* [Infographic]. ACEP Now. <https://www.acepnow.com/article/ten-4-faces-p-a-mnemonic-to-help-you-spot-signs-of-child-abuse/>

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Magana, J. N. & Ryan, M.T. (2020). *Upper Frenulum Tear* [Photograph]. *Prepare for the Pediatric Emergency Medicine Board*. https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-3-030-28372-8_17